

Chronic Pain Management

Pain Journal, Trigger Tracker & Coping Toolkit

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A Comprehensive Health & Wellness Workbook

Medical Disclaimer

MEDICAL DISCLAIMER: This workbook is for informational purposes only and does not constitute medical advice. Always consult your healthcare provider before making changes to your diet, exercise, or medication. The author is not a licensed medical professional. Never disregard professional medical advice or delay seeking it because of something you have read in this workbook.

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Introduction

Living with chronic pain is exhausting, isolating, and often misunderstood. This workbook is designed to be your daily companion in managing pain - not just surviving it, but building a meaningful life alongside it.

You will learn evidence-based strategies for tracking triggers, managing flare-ups, communicating with healthcare providers, and finding what works for YOUR unique pain experience.

Who This Book Is For

- People with chronic pain lasting 3+ months
- Those with fibromyalgia, arthritis, or back pain
- Anyone managing pain alongside medical treatment
- People seeking non-pharmacological pain tools

Chapter 1: Understanding Chronic Pain

Pain Science: What We Now Know

Modern pain science reveals that chronic pain is NOT simply 'damage signals from tissues.' Pain is a complex output of the brain, influenced by biology, psychology, social context, beliefs, and emotions. This does NOT mean pain is 'in your head' - it is absolutely real. But understanding its complexity opens doors to more effective management.

Acute vs. Chronic Pain

- Acute pain: Protective alarm system. Usually proportional to tissue damage. Heals.
- Chronic pain: Pain lasting 3+ months. Nervous system becomes sensitized. Pain signals amplified. Often not proportional to tissue state.

Central Sensitization

In chronic pain, the nervous system becomes 'turned up' like a volume dial. This means normal sensations can be perceived as painful, and painful stimuli feel more intense. This is a real neurological change, not imagined.

Signs of Central Sensitization

- Pain that spreads beyond the original site
- Normal touch feels painful (allodynia)
- Heightened sensitivity to light, sound, or temperature
- Pain persists long after injury should have healed
- Fatigue, poor sleep, brain fog alongside pain

The Biopsychosocial Model of Pain

Pain is influenced by three interacting factors:

Biological

- Tissue health and inflammation
- Nervous system sensitivity
- Sleep quality and physical fitness
- Nutrition and overall health

Psychological

- Thoughts and beliefs about pain
- Mood (depression, anxiety)
- Attention and focus on pain
- Catastrophizing vs. acceptance

Social

- Support system and relationships
- Work and financial stress
- Social isolation
- Healthcare experiences

Chapter 2: Pain Assessment & Baseline

My Pain Profile

Primary pain condition: _____

Duration of chronic pain: ____ months/years

Pain locations (mark all): _____

Average pain level (0-10): ____

Worst pain level this month: ____

Best pain level this month: ____

Pain Impact Assessment

Rate impact (0=none, 10=complete interference):

Sleep: ____/10

Work/productivity: ____/10

Physical activity: ____/10

Social life: ____/10

Mood/emotional health: ____/10

Relationships: ____/10

Self-care: ____/10

Hobbies/enjoyment: ____/10

Concentration: ____/10

Independence: ____/10

Total Impact Score: ____/100

Known Triggers

List activities, foods, weather, stress that worsen pain:

Trigger #1: _____ Severity increase: ____/10

Trigger #2: _____ Severity increase: ____/10

Trigger #3: _____ Severity increase: ____/10

Trigger #4: _____ Severity increase: ____/10

Trigger #5: _____ Severity increase: ____/10

Trigger #6: _____ Severity increase: ____/10

Trigger #7: _____ Severity increase: ____/10

Trigger #8: _____ Severity increase: ____/10

What Helps

List things that reduce or help manage your pain:

Relief #1: _____ Effectiveness: ____/10

Relief #2: _____ Effectiveness: ____/10

Relief #3: _____ Effectiveness: ____/10

Relief #4: _____ Effectiveness: ____/10

Relief #5: _____ Effectiveness: ____/10

Relief #6: _____ Effectiveness: ____/10

Relief #7: _____ Effectiveness: ____/10

Relief #8: _____ Effectiveness: ____/10

Chapter 3: Pain Management Strategies

The Pain Management Toolbox

No single strategy eliminates chronic pain. The goal is building a diverse toolbox of techniques that together help you manage pain and improve function.

Pacing: Your Most Important Tool

Pacing means balancing activity and rest to avoid the boom-bust cycle:

- Boom: On good days, overdoing it because you feel better
- Bust: Days of increased pain and forced rest afterwards
- Pacing: Consistent moderate activity regardless of pain level

How to Pace

- Find your baseline: The activity level you can do WITHOUT a flare-up
- Set time limits, not completion goals
- Take breaks BEFORE pain increases
- Gradually increase by 10% per week only when stable
- On good days: Do the same amount, not more

Graded Exposure

Gradually reintroduce activities you've been avoiding due to pain:

- List avoided activities in order of fear/difficulty
- Start with the easiest, do a small amount
- Notice: Did the feared consequence happen?
- Gradually increase as confidence builds

Acceptance-Based Approaches

Acceptance does not mean giving up. It means stopping the fight against pain and redirecting energy toward living well despite pain.

- Acknowledge pain without judgment
- Focus on values and what matters to you
- Take action toward goals even with pain present
- Practice willingness to experience discomfort

Chapter 4: Daily Pain Journal

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 1

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

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Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

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Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

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Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

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Mood (1-10): _____
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Activity level (1-10): _____

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Mood (1-10): _____

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Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 4

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Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
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Mood (1-10): _____
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Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
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Mood (1-10): _____
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Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

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Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

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Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
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Mood (1-10): _____
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Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

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Pain level AM (0-10): _____

Pain level PM (0-10): _____

Pain locations: _____

Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 5

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
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Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

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Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
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Triggers noticed: _____
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Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

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Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/__

Pain level AM (0-10): _____

Pain level PM (0-10): _____

Pain locations: _____

Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 6

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

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Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

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Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
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Pain level PM (0-10): _____

Pain locations: _____

Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 7

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Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
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Mood (1-10): _____
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Triggers noticed: _____
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Pain locations: _____

Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 8

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Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
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Mood (1-10): _____
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Activity level (1-10): _____

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Mood (1-10): _____

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Activity level (1-10): _____

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Mood (1-10): _____

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Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 10

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Pain locations: _____
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Mood (1-10): _____

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Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

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Pain locations: _____
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Mood (1-10): _____

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Activity level (1-10): _____

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Mood (1-10): _____

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Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 13

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Pain level AM (0-10): _____
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Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
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Pain level PM (0-10): _____

Pain locations: _____

Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 14

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

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Pain level PM (0-10): _____

Pain locations: _____

Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 15

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/__

Pain level AM (0-10): _____

Pain level PM (0-10): _____

Pain locations: _____

Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Daily Pain & Activity Log - Page 16

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Pain level AM (0-10): _____
Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____
Triggers noticed: _____
Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
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Pain level PM (0-10): _____
Pain locations: _____
Activity level (1-10): _____
Sleep quality (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/__

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Pain level PM (0-10): _____

Pain locations: _____

Activity level (1-10): _____

Sleep quality (1-10): _____

Mood (1-10): _____

Strategies used: _____

Triggers noticed: _____

Wins today: _____

Chapter 5: Movement & Physical Therapy

Why Movement Matters

Movement is medicine for chronic pain. It may seem counterintuitive, but gentle, consistent movement actually reduces pain sensitivity over time by retraining the nervous system.

Gentle Movement Options

- Walking: Start with 5 minutes, increase gradually
- Swimming/water therapy: Joint-friendly, soothing
- Yoga: Gentle/restorative classes (not power yoga)
- Tai Chi: Slow, flowing movements, proven for pain
- Stretching: Daily gentle stretches for affected areas
- Pilates: Core strengthening, modified for pain

Movement Principles for Chronic Pain

- Start below what you think you can do
- Consistency over intensity (daily small amounts)
- Some discomfort is okay; sharp or escalating pain means stop
- Progress slowly (10% increase per week maximum)
- Never compare to pre-pain abilities
- Celebrate every minute of movement

Daily Gentle Stretching Routine

- Neck rolls: Slowly circle head 5x each direction
- Shoulder shrugs: Lift shoulders to ears, hold 5 sec, release x10
- Cat-cow stretches: On all fours, arch and round spine gently x10
- Knee-to-chest: Lying down, pull one knee to chest, hold 30 sec each
- Child's pose: Kneel, sit back on heels, arms forward, hold 1 min
- Gentle twist: Seated, twist to each side gently, hold 30 sec
- Hamstring stretch: Seated, reach toward toes, hold 30 sec
- Hip flexor stretch: Lunge position, hold 30 sec each side

Chapter 6: Mind-Body Techniques

Mindfulness for Pain

Mindfulness meditation has strong evidence for reducing pain perception and suffering. It works by changing how the brain processes pain signals.

Body Scan Meditation (15 minutes)

- Lie comfortably with eyes closed
- Notice breath for 2 minutes
- Bring attention to feet - notice sensations without judgment
- Slowly move attention up through each body part
- When reaching painful areas, breathe INTO the sensation
- Observe pain with curiosity, not resistance
- Continue through entire body to top of head

Breathing Techniques for Pain

Box Breathing

- Inhale for 4 counts
- Hold for 4 counts
- Exhale for 4 counts
- Hold for 4 counts
- Repeat 4-8 cycles

Elongated Exhale (activates parasympathetic)

- Inhale for 4 counts
- Exhale for 6-8 counts
- Repeat for 5 minutes

Cognitive Techniques

Challenging Pain Catastrophizing

Pain catastrophizing = magnifying, ruminating, or feeling helpless about pain

Catastrophic thought: _____

Evidence this is true: _____

Evidence against: _____

More balanced thought: _____

What would I tell a friend: _____

Chapter 7: Flare-Up Action Plan

My Personal Flare-Up Protocol

Complete this when you're feeling well so it's ready for flare days.

Level 1: Early Warning (pain increasing)

- Action 1: _____
- Action 2: _____
- Action 3: _____

Level 2: Moderate Flare (significantly worse)

- Action 1: _____
- Action 2: _____
- Action 3: _____

Level 3: Severe Flare (crisis level)

- Action 1: _____
- Action 2: _____
- Contact: _____

Flare-Up Reminders

- This will pass. Flares are temporary, even when they feel endless.
- You have survived every flare before this one.
- Rest is not weakness. It is a strategic recovery tool.
- You do not need to earn rest or justify it.
- Ask for help. People want to support you.

Week 1 Review

Date Range: __/__/__ to __/__/__

Average pain this week (0-10):

Highest pain day and possible trigger:

Lowest pain day - what helped:

Activities completed despite pain:

Strategies used and effectiveness:

Movement minutes this week:

Mood average (1-10):

Goal for next week:

Week 2 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Average pain this week (0-10):

Highest pain day and possible trigger:

Lowest pain day - what helped:

Activities completed despite pain:

Strategies used and effectiveness:

Movement minutes this week:

Mood average (1-10):

Goal for next week:

Week 3 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Average pain this week (0-10):

Highest pain day and possible trigger:

Lowest pain day - what helped:

Activities completed despite pain:

Strategies used and effectiveness:

Movement minutes this week:

Mood average (1-10):

Goal for next week:

Week 4 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Average pain this week (0-10):

Highest pain day and possible trigger:

Lowest pain day - what helped:

Activities completed despite pain:

Strategies used and effectiveness:

Movement minutes this week:

Mood average (1-10):

Goal for next week:

Week 5 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Average pain this week (0-10):

Highest pain day and possible trigger:

Lowest pain day - what helped:

Activities completed despite pain:

Strategies used and effectiveness:

Movement minutes this week:

Mood average (1-10):

Goal for next week:

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Why hasn't my pain gone away even though tests are normal?

Normal imaging does not mean no pain. Chronic pain involves nervous system sensitization - real neurological changes that don't show on X-rays or MRIs. Your pain is valid regardless of test results.

Q: Is it safe to exercise with chronic pain?

Yes, with appropriate pacing. Gentle, graded exercise is one of the most evidence-based treatments for chronic pain. Start well below your limit and increase very gradually.

Q: Will I always have this pain?

Many people experience significant improvement over time with proper management. The nervous system can recalibrate. Focus on function and quality of life rather than zero pain.

Q: Are pain medications the answer?

Medications can be part of a management plan but rarely solve chronic pain alone. A multimodal approach (movement, psychology, lifestyle, medication) typically works best.

Q: Why does weather affect my pain?

Barometric pressure changes may affect joint fluid and nerve sensitivity. While the exact mechanism isn't fully understood, this is a real phenomenon many people experience.

Q: How do I explain chronic pain to family?

Use analogies: 'My alarm system is stuck on - it fires even without danger.' Share educational resources. Invite them to a doctor's appointment. Be direct about what helps and what doesn't.

Q: Is chronic pain 'all in my head'?

No. Chronic pain is real and involves measurable changes in the nervous system. The brain processes all pain - this doesn't make it less real. Anyone suggesting otherwise is uninformed.

Q: Should I push through pain or rest?

Neither extreme works. Pushing through leads to flares; excessive rest leads to deconditioning. Pacing - consistent moderate activity with planned rest - is the evidence-based approach.

Quick-Reference: Daily Pain Management Checklist

- ☐ Completed gentle movement/stretching
- ☐ Practiced pacing (breaks before pain increases)
- ☐ Used mind-body technique (breathing, meditation)
- ☐ Recorded pain level and activities in journal
- ☐ Prioritized sleep hygiene
- ☐ Connected with someone (social support)
- ☐ Did one enjoyable activity despite pain
- ☐ Practiced acceptance/self-compassion

Notes & Reflections

Use these pages to record your thoughts, observations, and insights as you work through this workbook.

Notes - Page 1

Date: ____/____/____

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Notes - Page 2

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Notes - Page 3

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About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a health and wellness content creator dedicated to making evidence-based health information accessible and actionable. Through carefully designed workbooks and guides, Daniel helps people take control of their health journey with practical tools, trackers, and strategies.

For more health and wellness resources, visit our Etsy shop for additional workbooks, planners, and guides covering nutrition, fitness, mental health, and chronic condition management.

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- Share your progress - we love hearing success stories

Thank you for investing in your health. You deserve to feel your best.